



Photographs by ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

A WORKER picks fruit from one of the 16,000 avocado trees at ACA Groves, in San Diego County.

COLUMN ONE

Fighting to preserve the rare California avocado grower

One farmer pits himself against cheaper imports from Mexico and other obstacles, and braces for Trump’s trade policies

By Daniel Miller | REPORTING FROM VALLEY CENTER, CALIF.



AVOCADOS are as emblematic of California as oranges once were. [See Avocados A12]

Norman Kachuck stood on a loamy ridge overlooking his inheritance. Avocado trees blanketed the hillsides of ACA Groves in three directions, just a portion of a 372-acre spread studded with 16,000 specimens, many of them dense with branches weighed down by that quintessential California fruit.

The serene San Diego County property felt far from the chaotic epicenter of the global avocado industry in Mexico. Violence, corruption and environmental degradation have saturated the avocado trade there, causing the U.S. to briefly stop imports and senators to agitate for action by the federal government.

“Mexican avocado imports are tainted conflict fruit,” said Kachuck, 70, a former neurologist who heads his family’s business. “The Mexican avocado industry is corrupt and ungoverned — and the American consumer is being deceived.”

A deluge of inexpensive avocados from Mexico has imperiled the livelihoods of California growers, Kachuck among them.

Trump’s threat roils Chinese students, state

California universities would lose talent, key income source if visas were revoked. Critics allege xenophobia.

By DANIEL MILLER, CHRISTOPHER BUCHANAN, MELISSA GOMEZ AND HOWARD BLUME

The Trump administration’s announcement this week that Chinese students’ visas would be “aggressively” revoked has inflamed the uncertainty among the nation’s international students — and in California has ignited anger among leaders in the Chinese American community who said such a targeted action is “xenophobic.”

Little has been disclosed about the administration’s plan, which represents yet another salvo in President Trump’s combative push to reshape higher education, which has roiled academia,

disrupted campus life and spilled into courts across the country.

On Wednesday, Secretary of State Marco Rubio announced in a social media post that the visa revocations will include “those with connections to the Chinese Communist Party or studying in critical fields,” without elaborating on what areas of study would be targeted or whether the move would apply solely to college students.

Rubio said in a statement that the U.S. State Department and the Department of Homeland Security would revoke the visas, while also revising “visa criteria to enhance scrutiny of all future visa applications from the People’s Republic of China and Hong Kong.”

Scholars and international students fear such an action could jeopardize the academic future of tens of thousands of Chinese students enrolled at colleges across the country, and threaten billions of dollars in tuition payments desperately.

[See Visas, A7]

Justices’ ruling is a win for developers

Court sharply limits environmental impact statements, saying projects are too often postponed or blocked.

By DAVID G. SAVAGE AND HAYLEY SMITH

WASHINGTON — The Supreme Court on Thursday sharply limited the reach of environmental impact statements in a victory for developers.

In an 8-0 decision, the justices said these claims of the potential impact on the environment have been used too often to delay or block new projects.

“A 1970 legislative acorn has grown over the years into a judicial oak that has hindered infrastructure development under the guise of just a little more process. A course correction of sorts

is appropriate,” said Justice Brett M. Kavanaugh, speaking for the court.

He said judges and environmentalists have been given too much authority to hinder development.

“Fewer projects make it to the finish line. Indeed, fewer projects make it to the starting line. Those that survive often end up costing much more than is anticipated or necessary,” he said.

“And that in turn means fewer and more expensive railroads, airports, wind turbines, transmission lines, dams, housing developments, highways, bridges, subways, stadiums, arenas, data centers, and the like. And that also means fewer jobs, as new projects become difficult to finance and build in a timely fashion,” Kavanaugh added.

The decision could loom large in California and the West because the U.S. 9th Circuit Court of Appeals has

[See Environment, A7]

Waymo noise drives Santa Monica mad

Neighbors use unusual tactics to protest two lots full of constantly beeping vehicles.

By SALVADOR HERNANDEZ

There’s a battle brewing in Santa Monica with a fleet of unmanned, electric Waymo vehicles on one side, and exhausted, weary locals on the other.

City officials, a judge and even police have been forced to intercede after residents who say the self-driving cars are a nuisance banded together to push back against the local 56-vehicle fleet. They’ve reached out to the city. They’ve called Waymo. Now, some are trying unconventional tactics.

Using cones, cars and

[See Waymo, A10]



HON WING CHIU For The Times

THE ROBOTAXI fleet faces backlash over its constant beeping at charging lots.

Firm protecting homes in Malibu

Private security company hired by city patrols neighborhoods amid theft concerns in fire zone. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Teams set for a Series rematch

Yankees endure constant reminders of October meltdown as they visit the Dodgers this weekend. **SPORTS, B10**

FCC official’s ominous warning

Commissioner calls on people to “push back” against Trump’s actions that affect free speech and media. **BUSINESS, A9**

Weather

Mostly sunny, warmer. L.A. Basin: 86/61. **B6**

7 85944 00200 5